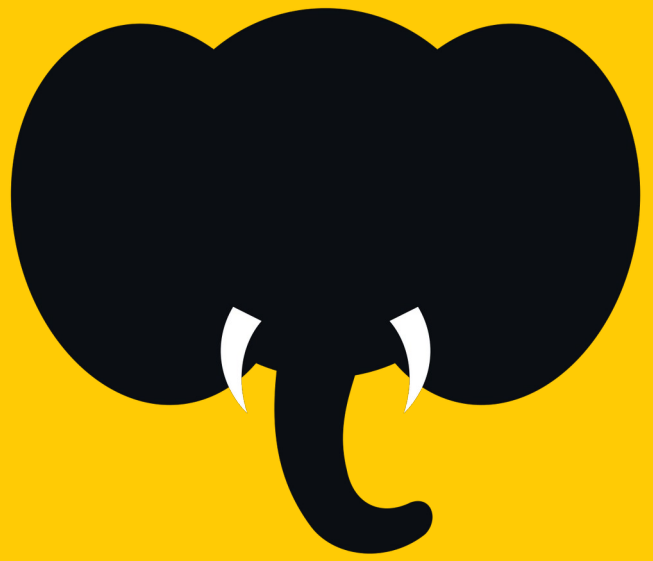
MTN Group Technology Hackathon 2026 · Showcase, 28 October

MoMo Agent Pay

A consent, mandate and risk layer so AI agents can pay on MoMo safely

The agent proposes. The mandate service disposes.



TEAM 032 ELEPHANTS

South Africa · Eswatini · Zambia

Vuyani Mofolo · Matthews Thekiso
Emmanuel Mukanku · Shepard Mwamba

Nomsa pays four bills a month. Every one, she types herself.

Electricity

on the 1st

a USSD session, by hand

Airtime for her mother

every week

a USSD session, by hand

School fees

in January

a USSD session, by hand

The stokvel

on the 25th

a USSD session, by hand

× 70.8 million monthly active MoMo users. 13 billion transactions in the first half of 2026, about 50,000 a minute.

Nomsa is our demo customer; her month is illustrative. Sources: MTN H1 2026 results (monthly active users, H1 transactions).

Every MTN assistant we found goes read-only the moment money appears.

Not because AI can't pay.

Because MoMo has no word for **permission.**

We found no MTN assistant that can pay a third party on a standing instruction. Agents are arriving anyway, through chat and partner apps, and will route around MoMo to card and bank rails that already have mandates.

ON MTN'S OWN ROADMAP

2030

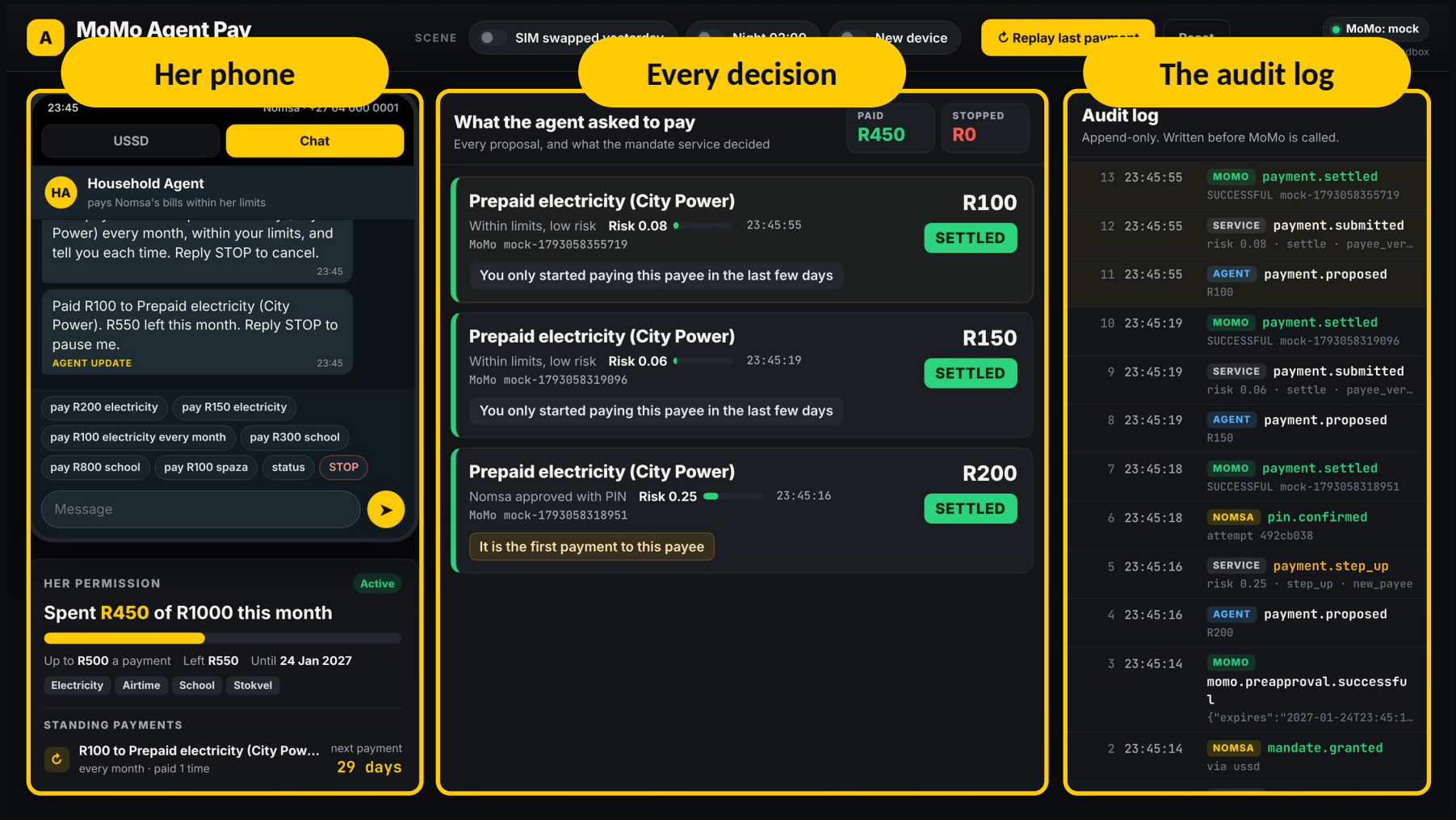
"Agentic commerce" and "AI premium" are named outcomes on the Group Fintech roadmap.

Nothing is shipped behind them yet.

Sources: Capital Markets Day, June 2026 (Fintech deck: agentic commerce, AI premium); team research, 20 Oct 2026 (MTN assistants reviewed).

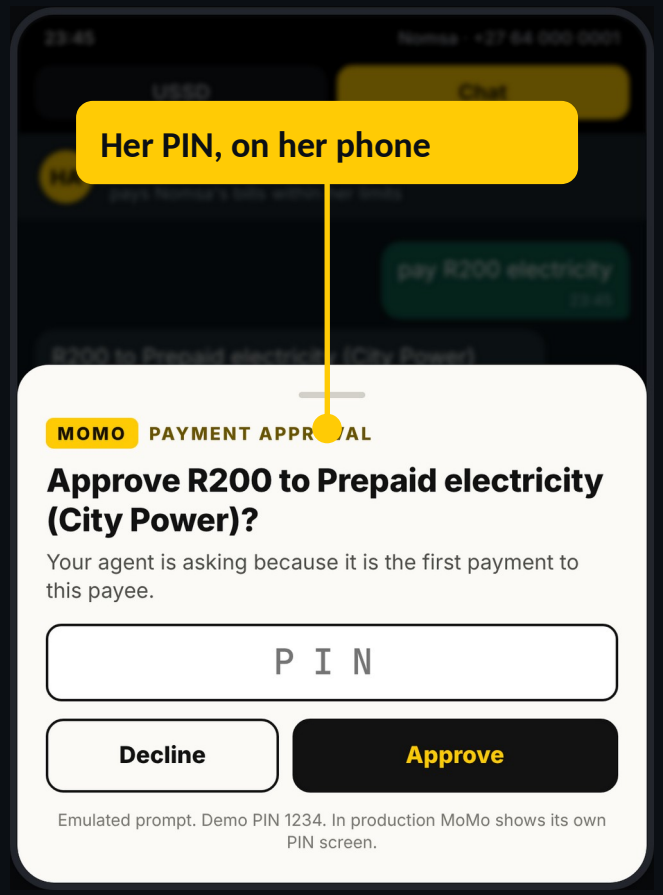
What you are about to see

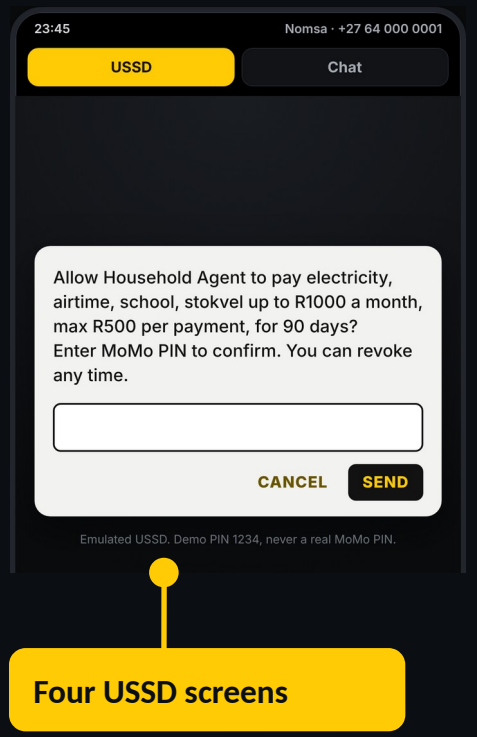
Let me show you →

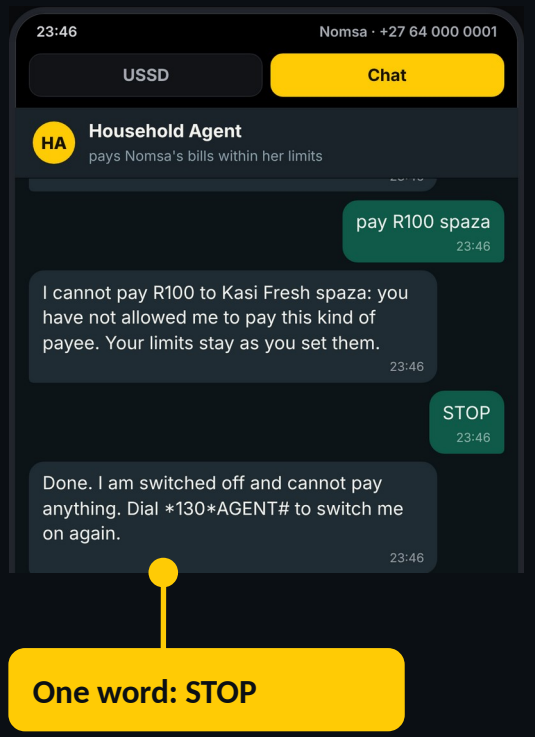


Rands on screen, EUR in the sandbox call. Payees are demo payees. Scenes in docs/DEMO_SCRIPT.md.

Four screens to grant. Her PIN to confirm. One word to stop.







The agent's credential is refused there: 403

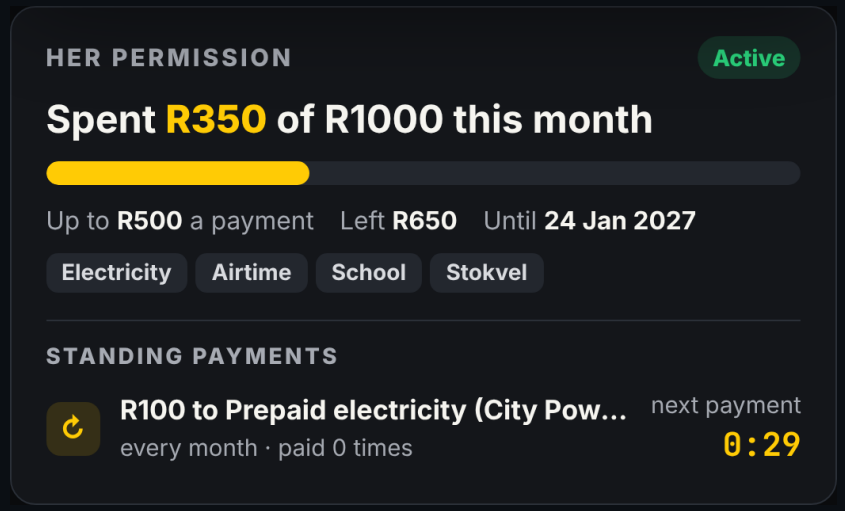
STOP is handled before any model sees the message

Plain language on her screen. No codes, no scores

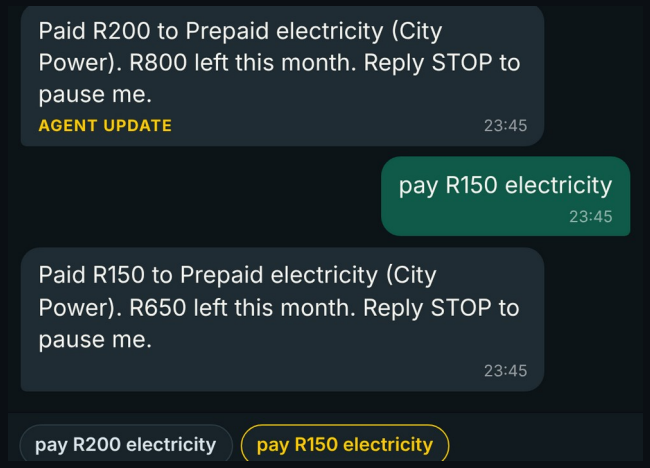
The agent proposes. The mandate service disposes.

Shown live a moment ago. docs/DEMO_SCRIPT.md, docs/ARCHITECTURE.md.

A wallet that pays on a standing mandate is not a dormant wallet



Pays on its own. Tells her each time.



Inside limits she set once. Every payment reported, every block explained in words.

WALLETS THAT WENT QUIET

3m of ~11m

active of registered MoMo wallets, South Africa, Dec 2024

5m of 30m+

active of registered MoMo wallets, Nigeria

WHERE MTN WANTS MOMO REVENUE TO GO

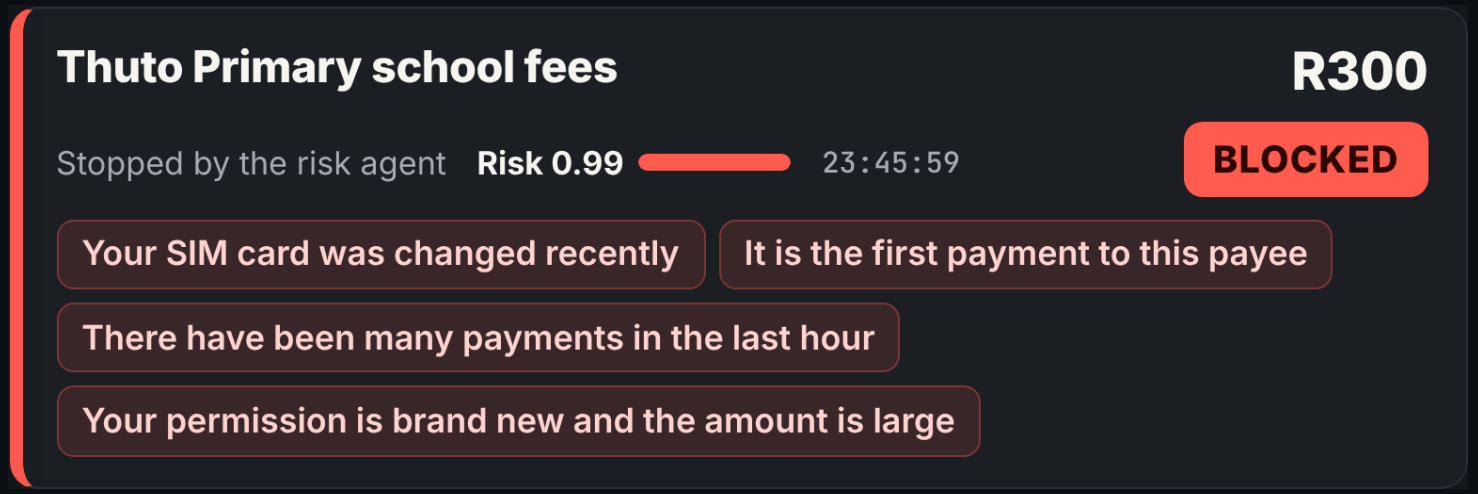
37.4% → 50%+

advanced services' share of MoMo revenue today, and the target above half by 2030. Agent-initiated payments are an advanced service.

Sources: MTN H1 2026 results; Capital Markets Day, June 2026; dormancy from team research section 04 (SA Dec 2024; Nigeria). Demo payees, mock MoMo on screen.

The most valuable payment in this demo is the one that didn't happen

SIM swapped yesterday — *a classic account-takeover signal*



R300 · NEVER LEFT HER WALLET

MoMo was never called.

Blocked, and explained in words she can act on.

This is the moment she decides she can trust it.

She hands something over and still feels in control. Her limits stay as she set them.

Shown live a moment ago. The SIM-swap signal is a demo switch; in production it could use the SIM Swap API MTN lists on Chenosis, subject to access. risk/MODEL_CARD.md.

MoMo has the primitives. What it lacks is a permission an agent can hold.

MOMO HAS TODAY

- **Request-to-pay**
  one PIN per payment
- **Pre-approval**
  standing authority for a partner
- **Consent tokens**
  scoped until she revokes

WHAT AN AGENT NEEDS, WHICH AGENT PAY ADDS

- **Per-agent identity**
- **Payee scope**
- **Customer-set caps**
- **A risk decision**
- **A kill switch**
- **Delegated-authority audit**

On top of MTN's primitives, not instead of them

On cards this exists. Mastercard, which holds 3.8% of MTN's fintech business, launched agent payments on cards in 2025. **We found no mobile-money equivalent.**

Sources: momodeveloper.mtn.com use-case docs, read 20 Oct 2026 (docs/MOMO_API_FINDINGS.md); team research section 10 (Mastercard).

Live where pre-approval can be switched on. Then the quiet wallets.

LIVE

558k

active MoMo users, Eswatini

4.16m

active MoMo users, Zambia

where pre-approval can be enabled with the local MoMo team

SCALING

Nigeria · South Africa

large registered bases, most of them quiet wallets

14 markets

list the MoMo Open API on the developer portal, including South Africa, Eswatini and Zambia. One mandate contract everywhere.

R30bn

of AI value creation in three to five years (Charles Molapisi, Group CTIO, June 2026). A working path, on APIs MTN already runs.

Revenue follows MoMo's existing model. Pricing is MTN Fintech's call, not ours.

Sources: team research section 07 (first markets); momodeveloper.mtn.com footer, 20 Oct 2026; CMD AI and Fintech decks and TechCentral interviews, June 2026 (research sections 00, 02, 04).

Everything you saw ran on the live MoMo sandbox



MoMo: sandbox

Real pre-approval, 90 days. Three real settlements with MoMo transaction ids, one on the agent's own schedule. The block never called MoMo. All scenes pass in 40 s.

6.9 ms

p50 per payment decision (p95 11.3 ms)

340 / s

decisions on a 4-vCPU box, untuned

0 tokens

language-model tokens per decision: rules plus a small logistic regression

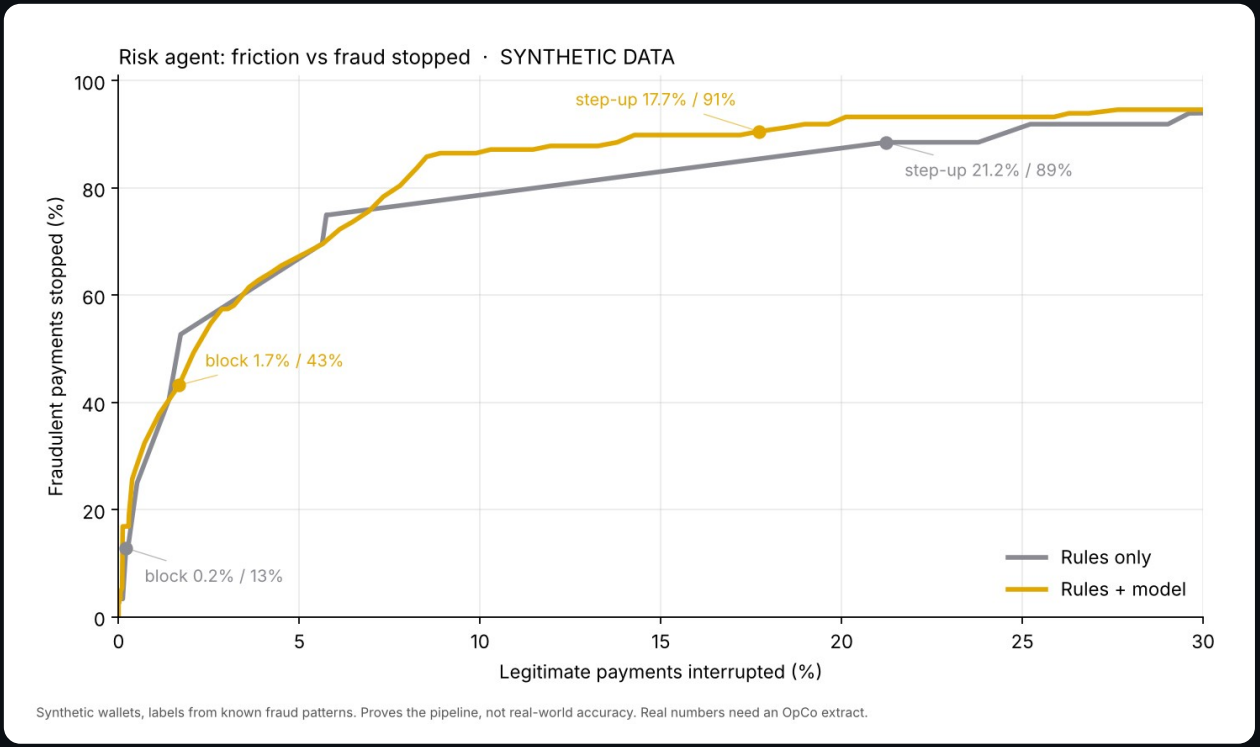
18 + 5

API tests and risk tests, plus a scripted rehearsal of every scene

> ***"I can't ignore your limits, even if it's urgent."***
>
> The brain only talks: Claude, four tools, it can only propose. Asked on 27 Oct to ignore its limits, it refused. Three Claude models, seven lines each, all seven right. We run the cheapest: $0.0002 per conversation turn, about 4 seconds (Haiku 5.5, measured 27 Oct). Opus and Sonnet are one setting away.

Sources: docs/momo/LIVE_RUN.md (27 Oct); docs/BENCHMARK.md (26 Oct; not load-tested at production scale); docs/LLM_BENCHMARK.md (27 Oct). "The big metric here is going to be the token per watt": Charles Molapisi, June 2026. Rands on screen, EUR in the sandbox call.

The hard controls never depend on a score



Synthetic data, labelled as such. Rules alone stop 88.5% of fraud; rules + model 90.5%, with 43% blocked outright instead of 13%. Weak on unseen patterns (20% on velocity bursts), so the rules stay on.

NEVER A SCORE

- The mandate's scope and caps
- Her PIN on the first payment to any payee; an agent credential gets 403
- STOP revokes everything in one transaction
- Audit row written before MoMo is called

OPEN, AND WE SAY SO

- Who bears a loss inside a valid mandate
- Whether this is payment initiation under SARB or Bank of Zambia rules

Sources: risk/MODEL_CARD.md (synthetic data, 26 Oct); docs/REGULATORY_NOTE.md (working draft, not legal advice). Never holds funds; mandates modelled on DebiCheck and MoMo pre-approval; POPIA, in-country.

Six things turn this into a pilot

1 **A named product owner**
in MTN Group Fintech

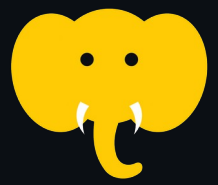
2 **Pre-approval in production**
confirmed for Eswatini and Zambia

3 **SIM Swap API access**
so the demo switch becomes MTN's signal

4 **A labelled fraud extract**
from one OpCo, to replace synthetic numbers

5 **An Azure environment**
in-country, to load-test and host

6 **A regulatory-sandbox pilot**
MoMo first; Eswatini or Zambia



TEAM 032
ELEPHANTS

VM
Vuyani Mofolo
Lead, product

MT
Matthews Thekiso
Full stack

EM
Emmanuel Mukanku
Full stack

SM
Shepard Mwamba
Machine learning

The agent proposes. The mandate service disposes.

Everything in the entry is assigned to MTN under clause 8 of the T&Cs. Thank you.